Class 7 Social Science – Chapter 4: New Beginnings: Cities and States

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Topic 1: First and Second Urbanisation of India

Q1. What is urbanisation?

Answer: Urbanisation is the process by which towns and cities develop and grow.

Q2. What was the First Urbanisation of India?

Answer: The First Urbanisation refers to the growth of cities during the Indus Valley or Harappan Civilisation. These cities had organised streets, markets, buildings, specialised workers and sanitation systems.

Q3. What happened to the Harappan Civilisation?

Answer: In the early second millennium BCE, the Harappan Civilisation disintegrated. Some cities were abandoned, while some people continued living there with a rural or village lifestyle.

Q4. Why did urban life decline after the Harappan Civilisation?

Answer: Many important features of Harappan urban life disappeared, including elaborate buildings, crowded streets, busy markets, specialised occupations, writing, sanitation systems and large administrative structures.

Q5. What is the Second Urbanisation of India?

Answer: The Second Urbanisation was a new phase of urban growth that began in the first millennium BCE, mainly in the Ganga plains, parts of the Indus basin and neighbouring regions. It gradually spread to other parts of the Indian subcontinent.

Q6. When did the Second Urbanisation begin?

Answer: It began in the first millennium BCE.

Q7. How do historians know about the Second Urbanisation?

Answer: Historians mainly use two sources:

1. Archaeological excavations of ancient urban centres.
2. Ancient literature, including late Vedic, Buddhist and Jain texts.

Q8. Why is the Second Urbanisation important in Indian history?

Answer: It led to the growth of cities, organised states, trade networks, new technologies and new political and social developments.

Q9. Where did the Second Urbanisation begin?

Answer: It began mainly in the Ganga plains, parts of the Indus basin and neighbouring regions.

Q10. What is the main difference between the First and Second Urbanisation?

Answer: The First Urbanisation was associated with the Harappan Civilisation. The Second Urbanisation developed in the first millennium BCE with the growth of janapadas, mahajanapadas, new cities, iron technology and wider trade networks.

First Urbanisation vs Second Urbanisation

First Urbanisation	Second Urbanisation
Associated with the Harappan Civilisation.	Associated with the growth of janapadas and mahajanapadas.
Flourished before its decline in the early second millennium BCE.	Began in the first millennium BCE.
Known for planned cities, drainage and copper/bronze metallurgy.	Known for iron technology, coins, new cities and expanding trade.

Harappan urban life later declined.	Urban growth spread across many regions of India.

The textbook's comparison activity on page 74 asks students to compare the two phases. The table below gives a suitable set of answers.

Feature	First Urbanisation	Second Urbanisation
Ganga plains	No	Yes
Monasteries	No	Yes
Literature	Yes	Yes
Trade	Yes	Yes
Warfare	Not established by this chapter's comparison	Yes
Copper/bronze	Yes	Yes
Iron	No	Yes

Note: This is a school-level comparison based on the chapter's framing, not a claim that every feature was completely absent from every region in the earlier period.

Topic 2: Janapadas and Mahajanapadas

A. Janapadas

Q1. What is a janapada?

Answer: A janapada was an early territorial state associated with a clan or group of people and usually led by a raja.

Q2. What is the meaning of the word janapada?

Answer: It is a Sanskrit word meaning “where the people (jana) have set foot (pada)”, that is, where people have settled.

Q3. How did janapadas develop?

Answer: People formed clans or groups that probably shared a common language and common customs. Each group became associated with a territory led by a raja.

Q4. When did janapadas emerge?

Answer: They emerged in parts of north and central India from the end of the second millennium BCE.

Q5. What helped janapadas grow?

Answer: Expanding trade networks helped janapadas grow and connect with one another.

B. Mahajanapadas

Q6. What is a mahajanapada?

Answer: A mahajanapada was a larger territorial state formed when some smaller states merged together.

Q7. When did mahajanapadas develop?

Answer: Some early states had merged into larger units by the eighth or seventh centuries BCE.

Q8. How many mahajanapadas are commonly mentioned in ancient texts?

Answer: Sixteen mahajanapadas are commonly mentioned.

Q9. Name the sixteen mahajanapadas.

Answer:

1. Anga
2. Magadha
3. Vajji or Vrijji
4. Malla
5. Kosala
6. Vatsa
7. Kashi
8. Chedi
9. Kuru
10. Panchala
11. Matsya
12. Surasena
13. Assaka or Ashmaka
14. Avanti
15. Gandhara
16. Kamboja

Q10. What were the geographical limits of the mahajanapadas?

Answer: They extended from Gandhara in the northwest to Anga in the east, and Ashmaka was located in central India near the Godavari River.

Q11. Why were many mahajanapadas located in the Ganga plains?

Answer: The Ganga plains had fertile soil for agriculture. Iron ore was available in nearby hills and mountains, and trade networks were developing.

Q12. Which were the most powerful mahajanapadas mentioned in the chapter?

Answer: Magadha, Kosala, Vatsa and Avanti.

Q13. Why were ancient capitals fortified?

Answer: Fortifications protected cities against attacks and helped rulers control the movement of people and goods.

Q14. What is a moat?

Answer: A moat is a deep, wide ditch surrounding a fort or fortified city. It was often filled with water for defence.

Q15. Why were the gateways of ancient fortified cities often narrow?

Answer: Narrow gateways helped guards control the movement of people and goods entering or leaving the city.

Q16. What is remarkable about many ancient capitals?

Answer: Many of them continue to exist as living cities today, with histories going back about 2,500 years or more.

Capitals of Important Mahajanapadas

The map on page 71 shows the mahajanapadas and their capitals.

Mahajanapada	Capital shown in the chapter
Magadha	Rajagriha
Kosala	Shravasti
Vatsa	Kaushambi
Avanti	Ujjayini

Q17. Which mahajanapada was located partly in present-day Bihar?

Answer: Magadha.

Q18. Which mahajanapada was located partly in present-day Uttar Pradesh?

Answer: Kosala.

Q19. Which mahajanapada was located partly in present-day Madhya Pradesh?

Answer: Avanti.

Q20. Which mahajanapada was located near the Godavari River?

Answer: Ashmaka.

Topic 3: Early Democratic Traditions

Q1. What were sabha and samiti?

Answer: Sabha and samiti were assemblies or councils where people discussed matters concerning their clan.

Q2. Who were the members of these assemblies?

Answer: Most members were probably elders of the clan.

Q3. Could a raja rule independently?

Answer: No. A good raja was expected to listen to the advice of the assemblies, ministers and administrators.

Q4. Could an incompetent ruler be removed?

Answer: According to some ancient texts, an incompetent ruler could be removed by the assembly. However, the chapter says that the available evidence is incomplete, so this should not be treated as a definite law.

Q5. What was a monarchy?

Answer: A monarchy was a system of government in which the raja was the ultimate authority. His position was usually hereditary.

Q6. Name three powerful monarchies mentioned in the chapter.

Answer: Magadha, Kosala and Avanti.

Q7. What were ganas or sanghas?

Answer: Ganas or sanghas were political systems in which assemblies had greater power and took important decisions through discussion and sometimes voting.

Q8. Which mahajanapadas had a system of governance different from monarchy?

Answer: Vajji or Vrijji and Malla.

Q9. How were important decisions made in the ganas or sanghas?

Answer: Members of the assembly discussed important matters and, when necessary, made decisions through voting.

Q10. How was the ruler selected in these systems?

Answer: The assembly selected the ruler.

Q11. Why are ganas and sanghas sometimes called early republics?

Answer: They are called early republics because the assembly selected the ruler and made major decisions instead of giving all authority to a hereditary king.

Q12. Were these early republics exactly like modern democracies?

Answer: No. They had some democratic features, such as discussion, voting and selecting rulers, but they were not the same as modern democratic systems.

Q13. What were the main duties of a king in a monarchy?

Answer: A king collected taxes, maintained law and order, built fortifications, maintained an army and defended his territory.

Q14. What is the difference between a monarchy and a gana or sangha?

Monarchy	Gana or Sangha
The raja held the highest authority.	The assembly held greater power.
The ruler's position was usually hereditary.	The assembly selected the ruler.
The king took decisions with advice from ministers and elders.	Important decisions were made through discussion and sometimes voting.

Topic 4: More Innovations — Iron, Coins and Trade

A. Iron Technology

Q1. What is metallurgy?

Answer: Metallurgy is the process of extracting metals from ores and shaping them into useful objects.

Q2. Which major technological change took place during the Second Urbanisation?

Answer: Iron metallurgy became an important technological development.

Q3. How did iron tools help agriculture?

Answer: Iron tools helped people clear land and cultivate larger areas, increasing agricultural production.

Q4. Why were iron weapons important?

Answer: Iron could be used to make sharp and relatively light weapons, such as swords, spears and arrows.

Q5. How did iron technology help urbanisation?

Answer: Better agricultural tools supported increased food production. This helped sustain larger populations and the growth of towns and cities.

Q6. How did warfare affect the mahajanapadas?

Answer: Warfare between neighbouring mahajanapadas sometimes led to the formation of new kingdoms and empires. Alliances also played a role.

Q7. Did iron technology develop only during the Second Urbanisation?

Answer: No. The chapter explains that iron extraction and shaping had developed in some regions earlier. Iron tools became widespread by the late second millennium BCE.

B. Coins

Q8. Why were coins introduced in ancient India?

Answer: Coins became necessary because trade was growing and goods were exchanged across different regions.

Q9. What were the first Indian coins made of?

Answer: The first Indian coins described in the chapter were made of silver.

Q10. What were punch-marked coins?

Answer: Punch-marked coins were coins on which symbols were stamped or punched into the metal.

Q11. Which other metals were later used to make coins?

Answer: Copper, gold and other metals were also used.

Q12. Did every mahajanapada use the same coins?

Answer: No. Generally, each mahajanapada issued its own coins, but coins from neighbouring regions were also used and exchanged in trade.

C. Trade and Urban Growth

Q13. How did trade help the growth of cities?

Answer: Trade connected regions, increased the exchange of goods and supported craftspeople, traders and other workers. This encouraged the growth of towns and cities.

Q14. How did roads help ancient India?

Answer: Roads helped people, goods, ideas and religious teachings travel between different regions.

Q15. What was the importance of trade networks?

Answer: Trade networks connected states and cities, helped people exchange goods and encouraged economic growth.

Q16. What is the connection between agriculture, trade and urbanisation?

Answer: Improved agricultural production supported larger populations. Surplus goods could be traded, and trade supported specialised occupations and the growth of cities.

Topic 5: The Varna–Jati System

A. Social Organisation

Q1. Why do complex societies develop different groups?

Answer: Complex societies need people to perform different tasks, such as farming, trade, administration, education, crafts and religious activities.

Q2. What is the varna–jati system?

Answer: It was a system of social organisation in India involving two categories: varna and jati.

Q3. What is jati?

Answer: Jati refers to a group or community of people associated with a particular occupation and livelihood.

Q4. How were jati-related skills passed from one generation to another?

Answer: Skills connected with occupations such as agriculture, metallurgy, commerce and crafts were generally passed from parents and communities to younger generations.

Q5. What were sub-jatis?

Answer: Sub-jatis were smaller groups within a jati. They could develop their own customs and traditions relating to marriage, rituals and food habits.

Q6. What is varna?

Answer: Varna was a category of social organisation that emerged from Vedic texts.

Q7. Name the four varnas.

Answer: Brahmins, Kshatriyas, Vaishyas and Shudras.

Q8. What were the traditional roles of the four varnas?

Answer:

- Brahmins: Preserved and spread knowledge and performed rituals.
- Kshatriyas: Defended society and land and took part in warfare when needed.
- Vaishyas: Engaged in trade, business and agriculture to increase society's wealth.
- Shudras: Worked as artisans, craftspeople, workers or servants.

Q9. What is the origin of the English word “caste”?

Answer: The word “caste” comes from the Portuguese word casta. Portuguese travellers used it while trying to understand Indian society in the sixteenth century CE.

Q10. Is caste exactly the same as varna?

Answer: Not necessarily. Some scholars use caste to refer to varna, while many others use it for jati. Some use it for the entire varna–jati system.

B. Changes and Inequalities

Q11. Could people change their occupations in early Indian society?

Answer: Yes. Historical evidence from texts and inscriptions shows that people sometimes changed their occupations when circumstances required it.

Q12. Give an example of a change in occupation mentioned in the chapter.

Answer: During a long drought or natural disaster, farmers might migrate to a city and take up other occupations. Some Brahmins also moved into trade or military activities.

Q13. How did the varna–jati system organise society?

Answer: It organised social and economic activities by grouping people according to social categories and occupations.

Q14. How did the system lead to inequalities over time?

Answer: Over time, the system became more rigid. Some groups gained more wealth, power and influence than others, while lower jatis and certain excluded communities faced discrimination.

Q15. Was the varna–jati system always equally rigid?

Answer: No. The chapter explains that it was more flexible in earlier periods and became more rigid over time, particularly during British rule.

Q16. Why is equality important in society?

Answer: Equality helps ensure that everyone is treated with dignity and fairness and has opportunities to participate in society without discrimination.

Q17. What is the difference between varna and jati?

Varna	Jati
A category that emerged from Vedic texts.	A community associated with an occupation and livelihood.
Traditionally divided into four groups.	Includes many communities and sub-jatis.
Describes broad social categories.	Often relates to specific occupations, customs and traditions.

Topic 6: Developments Elsewhere in India

A. Ancient Communication Routes

Q1. Why did communication routes become important in the first millennium BCE?

Answer: They supported trade, pilgrimages, military campaigns and communication between different regions.

Q2. What was Uttarapatha?

Answer: Uttarapatha was an important route connecting the northwestern regions with the Ganga plains and extending towards eastern India.

Q3. What was Dakshinapatha?

Answer: Dakshinapatha was an important route that started from Kaushambi, near present-day Prayagraj, and crossed the Vindhya Range towards southern India.

Q4. How did these routes help ancient India?

Answer: They connected northern and southern regions, encouraged trade and allowed people, goods, ideas and teachings to travel.

Q5. Why were ports important?

Answer: Ports on the western and eastern coasts were important centres of trade, connecting inland regions with overseas markets.

B. Cities in Eastern India

Q6. What was Sisupalgarh?

Answer: Sisupalgarh, near present-day Bhubaneswar in Odisha, was an important ancient city and the capital of the Kalinga region.

Q7. What were the main features of Sisupalgarh?

Answer: It had a square ground plan, strong fortifications and broad streets.

Q8. How did fortifications and gateways help ancient cities?

Answer: Fortifications protected cities, while controlled gateways helped guards regulate the movement of people and goods.

C. Southern India

Q9. When did cities begin emerging in southern India according to the chapter?

Answer: Cities began emerging from about 400 BCE, although some recent archaeological findings suggest earlier commercial activity.

Q10. Name the three kingdoms that emerged in southern India around this period.

Answer: The Cholas, Cheras and Pandyas.

Q11. What resources made southern India important for trade?

Answer: Precious and semiprecious stones, gold and spices were important resources.

Q12. With whom did southern India trade?

Answer: Southern regions traded with other parts of India and with kingdoms and empires overseas.

Q13. What does the archaeological site of Kodumanal show?

Answer: The site near Erode in Tamil Nadu provides evidence of shell and gemstone industries.

Q14. What role did ancient Tamil literature play in studying southern kingdoms?

Answer: Ancient Tamil literature mentions these kingdoms and several of their kings, providing evidence about their history.

D. The End of the Mahajanapadas

Q15. What happened by around 300 or 200 BCE?

Answer: Almost the entire Indian subcontinent had become interconnected through the movement of goods and culture. Around the same time, the mahajanapadas ceased to exist, making way for new political developments.

Q16. What is the main message of the chapter's timeline on page 79?

Answer: It shows the broad sequence of the Harappan Civilisation, the rise of janapadas and the development of mahajanapadas between 1900 BCE and 300 BCE.

Part 7: All Textbook Questions and Activities

The following answers cover the questions and activities on pages 70–71, 74, 76 and 81 of the uploaded NCERT chapter.

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ssc7-cbse-ch04-new-beginnings-cities-and-states.pdf

Question 1. Consider the quotation at the start of the chapter. What did Kautilya recommend for a kingdom? Is it very different today?

Answer:

Kautilya recommended that a kingdom should have:

1. A well-protected capital and fortified towns.
2. Enough fertile land to support its population.
3. Mines, forests, pastures and other natural resources.
4. Reliable sources of water, not only rain.
5. Good roads and waterways.
6. A productive economy with different kinds of goods.

These ideas are still important today. Modern countries also need security, food, water, transport, natural resources and a strong economy. However, modern governments also focus on education, healthcare, technology, equality and environmental protection.

Question 2. According to the text, how were rulers chosen in early Vedic society?

Answer:

The chapter refers to an earlier lesson on India's cultural roots but does not explain the method in detail here. In early Vedic society, the selection of a ruler could involve the approval or choice of the people or their assemblies. The exact method varied, and it should not be assumed that every ruler was chosen in the same way.

Question 3. Imagine you are a historian studying ancient India. What sources would you use to learn more about the mahajanapadas? Explain how each source might help.

Answer:

As a historian, I would use the following sources:

1. Archaeological excavations: They reveal the remains of ancient cities, buildings, fortifications and roads.
2. Coins: They provide information about trade, economic activities and symbols used by ancient states.
3. Ancient literature: Vedic, Buddhist and Jain texts provide information about rulers, political systems, cities and religious ideas.
4. Inscriptions: They may provide information about rulers, administration and important events.
5. Maps and geographical evidence: They help identify the locations of ancient states, rivers, trade routes and capitals.

By studying these sources together, historians can develop a better understanding of the mahajanapadas.

Question 4. Why was the development of iron metallurgy important for the growth of urbanism in the first millennium BCE?

Answer:

Iron metallurgy was important for several reasons:

1. Iron tools helped people cultivate larger areas of land.
2. Better agricultural tools helped increase food production.
3. Increased food production supported larger populations.
4. Iron was used to make weapons such as swords, spears and arrows.
5. Growing agriculture, trade and specialised occupations helped towns and cities develop.

Therefore, iron technology contributed significantly to the growth of urban centres during the Second Urbanisation.

Part 8: Additional Questions from Textbook Activities

A. Why should a complex society divide itself into different groups?

Answer: A complex society needs people to perform different tasks. Farmers produce food, traders exchange goods, craftspeople make useful objects, and administrators manage public affairs. Different groups help society perform these activities.

B. Name other professions that existed in the first millennium BCE.

Answer: Some likely professions included farmers, traders, potters, weavers, smiths, carpenters, builders, soldiers, teachers, healers, administrators and transport workers.

C. What does the map of the sixteen mahajanapadas tell us?

Answer: The map on page 71 shows the approximate locations of the sixteen mahajanapadas and their capitals. It shows that many states were concentrated in the Ganga plains, while others extended towards the northwest and central India.

D. What does the comparison with the regions in the Mahabharata suggest?

Answer: Several names, such as Gandhara, Kuru, Panchala, Matsya, Kosala and Magadha, appear in both historical traditions and the map of the mahajanapadas. This suggests that some regional names and political traditions continued over long periods. However, the regions and their boundaries may not have remained exactly the same.

E. Why did trade increase during this period?

Answer: Growing towns, specialised occupations, agricultural production, coins and better communication routes helped trade expand between different regions.

F. What can we learn from the photograph of the ancient gateway at Sisupalgarh on page 78?

Answer: The photograph shows a fortified gateway and a moat outside the city. The narrow entrance helped control the movement of people and goods and provided additional security.

Part 9: Important Exam Questions

A. Very Short Answer Questions (1 mark)

Q1. What does BCE mean?

Answer: BCE means “Before Common Era”.

Q2. What does CE mean?

Answer: CE means “Common Era”.

Q3. What is a janapada?

Answer: An early territorial state associated with a clan or group of people.

Q4. How many mahajanapadas are commonly listed?

Answer: Sixteen.

Q5. What was the capital of Magadha?

Answer: Rajagriha.

Q6. What was the capital of Avanti?

Answer: Ujjayini.

Q7. What was the capital of Vatsa?

Answer: Kaushambi.

Q8. What were punch-marked coins?

Answer: Coins made by punching symbols into metal.

Q9. Name the two important ancient routes.

Answer: Uttarapatha and Dakshinapatha.

Q10. Name the three southern kingdoms mentioned in the chapter.

Answer: Cholas, Cheras and Pandyas.

Q11. Which metal became important during the Second Urbanisation?

Answer: Iron.

Q12. What was a moat?

Answer: A deep, wide ditch around a fort or fortified city, often filled with water.

B. Short Answer Questions (2–3 marks)

Q1. Explain three features of the Second Urbanisation.

Answer:

1. New towns and cities developed in many regions.
2. Iron tools and punch-marked coins became important.
3. Trade networks expanded, connecting different regions.

Q2. Why was Magadha powerful?

Answer: Magadha was one of the most powerful mahajanapadas. Its location in the fertile region of present-day Bihar supported agriculture, while growing trade and organised political and military systems helped it expand.

Q3. What were the main functions of ancient assemblies?

Answer: Assemblies discussed matters concerning the clan, advised rulers and participated in important decisions. In some ganas or sanghas, assemblies also selected rulers and used voting when necessary.

Q4. Why were coins important for trade?

Answer: Coins made the exchange of goods easier. They were used in different regions, and coins from neighbouring states were also exchanged in trade.

Q5. Explain the importance of Uttarapatha and Dakshinapatha.

Answer: These routes connected different parts of India. They supported trade, pilgrimages and military campaigns and helped people, goods and ideas travel between regions.

Q6. What were two important features of Sisupalgarh?

Answer: It had a square ground plan and strong fortifications. It also had broad streets and controlled gateways.

C. Long Answer Questions (4–5 marks)

Q1. Explain the rise and importance of the mahajanapadas.

Answer: Janapadas developed when clans or groups of people settled in territories under rulers. As trade networks expanded, some of these states merged into larger political units called mahajanapadas. By the eighth or seventh centuries BCE, sixteen mahajanapadas were commonly recognised. Many developed in the fertile Ganga plains, where agriculture, iron resources and trade supported their growth. They developed fortified capitals, armies, revenue systems and different forms of government. Their growth was an important part of India's Second Urbanisation.

Q2. Describe the different forms of government among the mahajanapadas.

Answer: Some mahajanapadas were monarchies, where the raja held the highest authority and the position was usually hereditary. The king collected taxes, maintained law and order, built fortifications and maintained an army. Magadha, Kosala and Avanti were powerful monarchies. Other states, such as Vajji and Malla, had systems called ganas or sanghas. Their assemblies held greater power, discussed important matters, sometimes voted and selected the ruler. These systems are often described as early republics.

Q3. Explain how technology and trade helped the Second Urbanisation.

Answer: Iron technology improved agricultural tools and helped people cultivate larger areas of land. Better weapons also supported the military strength of states. The growth of agriculture supported larger populations and specialised occupations. The introduction of punch-marked coins made trade easier. Roads such as Uttarapatha and Dakshinapatha connected different regions. Together, these developments encouraged trade, economic growth and the expansion of cities.

Q4. Explain the varna–jati system and its effects on Indian society.

Answer: The varna–jati system was a form of social organisation. Jati referred to communities often connected with particular occupations, while varna referred to four broad categories described in Vedic texts: Brahmins, Kshatriyas, Vaishyas and Shudras. The system helped organise social and economic activities, but it became more rigid over time. This contributed to inequalities and discrimination against lower jatis and some communities excluded from the system. The chapter explains that the system was more flexible in earlier periods than it became later.

Q5. Describe the growth of trade and cities in different parts of India.

Answer: During the first millennium BCE, roads connected northern, southern, eastern and western India. Uttarapatha linked the northwest with the Ganga plains, while Dakshinapatha connected Kaushambi with regions towards the south. Ports on the eastern and western coasts supported trade. Sisupalgarh developed as an important fortified city in the Kalinga region. In southern India, cities began emerging from about 400 BCE, and the Chola, Chera and Pandya kingdoms became important. Southern regions traded in precious stones, gold and spices with other parts of India and overseas regions.

Final Revision: Key Facts to Remember

Topic	Important fact
First Urbanisation	Harappan Civilisation
Second Urbanisation	Began in the first millennium BCE
Janapada	A territorial state associated with a clan
Mahajanapada	A larger state formed as some smaller states merged
Number of mahajanapadas	Sixteen
Powerful monarchies	Magadha, Kosala, Avanti and Vatsa
Early republics	Vajji and Malla
Important metal	Iron
First Indian coins in the chapter	Silver punch-marked coins
Social system	Varna–jati
Northern route	Uttarapatha

Southern route	Dakshinapatha
Ancient city in Odisha	Sisupalgarh
Southern kingdoms	Cholas, Cheras and Pandyas

Study tip: Learn the definitions first, practise the sixteen mahajanapadas and their important capitals on a map, and then revise the differences between monarchy and gana/sangha. The long-answer questions on iron technology, urbanisation and the varna–jati system are especially useful for examination preparation.